

Chapter 5: *The Photo That Refuses to Remember Her*

She didn't sleep well.

Not because she was anxious.

Not because anything dramatic happened.

But because her brain had developed a new habit:

replaying small moments and asking "are you sure?" in Mia's voice.

She hated that.

Mia would be proud.

In the morning, Mia was already in the kitchen.

Standing there like she had a schedule.

"You're thinking too loud again," Mia said.

"I didn't say anything."

"You don't have to. Your face is doing overtime."

She sat down at the table.

"I keep thinking about the café."

Mia poured water into a glass. "Which part?"

“There was only one drink.”

Mia paused for half a second.

Then continued pouring like nothing happened.

“There was one drink,” Mia agreed.

She frowned. “But I remember two.”

Mia finally looked at her.

“Memory and reality don’t always file their reports together.”

“That sounds like you made it up.”

“I did.”

That was supposed to be a joke.

But it didn’t land like one.

She decided to ignore it.

That was her coping strategy for most of life.

If something didn’t make sense, she just gave it time to become someone else’s problem.

So she cleaned.

Applied for jobs.

Folded clothes she would later unfold without wearing.

Mia supervised everything like a strict but emotionally unstable manager.

At noon, she opened her old photo folder again.

“Just checking something,” she muttered.

Mia immediately leaned over her shoulder.

“That’s never a good sentence.”

“Do you remember this café?”

She turned the screen.

A picture.

Her sitting at a table.

Smiling.

There was a drink in front of her.

And across from her—

a chair.

Empty.

She zoomed in.

The chair looked… slightly wrong.

Like it didn’t belong to the lighting of the world.

She frowned.

“I thought you were in this one.”

Mia didn't respond immediately.

That was becoming a pattern.

Then Mia said casually:

“I don't like cameras.”

“That's not an answer.”

“It's the answer I'm giving.”

She opened another photo.

Same café.

Different angle.

Still alone.

Another.

Alone again.

Her stomach tightened slightly.

“That's weird,” she said softly.

Mia yawned. “Or your photography skills are consistent.”

“I don't remember being alone.”

Mia leaned back against the counter.

“You’re rarely alone.”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“I know.”

That “I know” again.

Always too quick.

Always too accurate.

Later that day, she went out to run errands.

Mia came with her.

As usual.

Talking about everything and nothing.

Judging strangers like it was a hobby.

“This place has terrible lighting,” Mia said inside the grocery store.

“It’s a supermarket.”

“Exactly. They should still respect ambiance.”

She laughed despite herself.

That was the problem.

Even when things felt off—

Mia was still funny.

Still familiar.

Still... necessary.

At the checkout counter, something happened.

Small.

Almost nothing.

The cashier smiled at her.

Then looked past her.

Just slightly.

Like acknowledging someone standing beside her.

“Hi,” the cashier said politely.

She turned.

No one was there physically in that direction.

She froze.

Mia didn't react.

Not immediately.

Then softly:

“Don't overthink it.”

Her heart skipped.

“Did you see that?”

Mia nodded.

“People get distracted.”

“That looked intentional.”

Mia smiled.

“Or you’re becoming sensitive to patterns that don’t matter.”

That sounded like comfort.

But it felt like avoidance.

On the way home, she couldn’t stay quiet.

“Mia.”

“Yes?”

“Do you exist when I’m not looking at you?”

Mia laughed immediately.

Too quickly.

“Of course not,” Mia said.

Then added, lighter:

“I’m not a plant.”

That was supposed to make her relax.

But it didn't.

That night, she did something she didn't usually do.

She asked for proof.

Not out loud.

Just internally.

She sat on her bed and said:

"If you're real... say something I didn't expect."

Silence.

Then—

"You're not as stable as you pretend to be."

She blinked.

"That doesn't count. That's your usual insult."

Mia smiled.

"Then ask better questions."

She sighed.

"Fine. Tell me something about me that I don't know."

Mia tilted her head.

For once, she looked... thoughtful.

Not playful.

Not teasing.

Just quiet.

Then Mia said:

“You always think you started late.”

She froze slightly.

“That’s not surprising.”

Mia continued:

“But you didn’t start late. You just remember the waiting more than the moving.”

Silence.

Longer than before.

She frowned.

“...That sounded almost kind.”

Mia grinned again.

“I contain multitudes. Unfortunately.”

That made her laugh.

Against her will.

Against the tension building in her chest.

But later, when she lay in bed,

she kept thinking about the cashier.

The glance.

The pause.

Like someone acknowledging space where no one stood.

And Mia, beside her bed, quiet for longer than usual.

Not gone.

Just... careful.

And for the first time,

she started wondering something she didn't have words for yet:

If Mia was always there...

why did the world keep acting like she wasn't?